

Assignment:

Define a Project

Duration: 30 Minutes

Elaborating on Project Needs

Progressive elaboration is like deductive reasoning: you can start very broad, and through a series of questions, interviews, and inspection, you can deduce the specifics of a problem. Imagine a new project to build a house. If you were the project manager, you'd speak with the stakeholders to define the exact nature of the house project. You'd ask many questions to go from a general concept of a house to the specific nature of the house project. By progressively elaborating the concept of a house, you could learn everything from the square footage of the house down to the type of doorknobs that should be used.

Learning Objectives

In this exercise you will use the progressive elaboration technique to help you identify more information about the project requirements. By the end of the exercise you will be able to

- ▶ Use progressive elaboration
- ▶ Explore ideal questions to ask project customers
- ▶ Interview a project customer
- ▶ Gather project requirements
- ▶ Create specific questions about customer requirements

Critical Thinking

You are a customer of the GHY Company, and you're meeting with Thomas, the project manager. You have approached the GHY Company because you have a new idea to create a piece of software that will allow users to create movies from their photos and music online through your web site. Answer the following questions to participate in an example of progressive elaboration for your project:

1. What is the name of your software?

2. Will the software be available just on your web site, or can users download the software too?

3. Who is your audience for this software (business, home users)?

4. What is your business model for the software and web site? (How will you earn a profit?)

5. How will users share their creations?

Now pretend that you are the project manager and you need to progressively elaborate the proposed project. Create five more questions that you would ask of the client to progressive elaborate the project:

Progressive elaboration helps the project manager and the stakeholders learn the specifics of a project. As a project manager, you'll do progressive elaboration throughout the project, but most often in the early planning stages of a project.

Lab Solution: Elaborating on Project Needs

You are a customer of the GHY Company, and you're meeting with Thomas, the project manager. You have approached the GHY Company because you have a new idea to create a piece of software that will allow users to create movies from their photos and music online through your web site. In this exercise your answers will likely be wildly different than what is provided. These answers are possible solutions.

1. What is the name of your software?

DigiDog Photos

2. Will the software be available just on your web site, or can users download the software too?

The software will be created through our web services, but the end result is available for users to download and share.

3. Who is your audience for this software (business, home users)?

Our audience is primarily end users looking for a fun tool to enhance their pictures.

4. What is your business model for the software and web site? (How will you earn a profit?)

Our web-based service is totally free and supported by advertisers.

5. How will users share their creations?

Once the users are finished editing their photo creations, they can download their creation, e-mail it to their friends, or share it online through social media web sites.

6. Now pretend that you are the project manager and you need to progressively elaborate the proposed project. Create five more questions that you would ask of the client to progressive elaborate the project:
- ▶ Can you describe the typical user experience with your software?
 - ▶ Will you store the users' creation on your server, or will it be only temporarily available?
 - ▶ Are there legal concerns to consider for the photos and music the users add to their music?
 - ▶ Will the users' operating systems, such as Mac versus Windows, be anything to consider?
 - ▶ What social media sites will you need to connect to so that users can share their creations on these other sites?